

Threshold

Embodied Vision at the Edge of Disaster

Wang Yan · Exhibition Working Paper v0.1

GS Arts & Research Collective 2026–2027

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Abstract

Threshold is an AI-native short film that uses a first-person, bodycam-like perspective to place the viewer inside an urban disaster. Set in contemporary Brooklyn, the film moves from an intimate, almost dreamlike encounter with cherry blossoms into rain. A dog appears not only as a companion or image of vulnerability, but as an ethical weight inside the scene: the presence that turns danger into responsibility.

The title names a boundary in several registers at once — a doorway, a warning line, a flood level, and a psychological point of no return. Rather than presenting disaster as spectacle, *Threshold* treats the camera as a breathing body. The project explores how AI-generated cinema can simulate ethical pressure.

Research Question

Can AI-generated film move beyond image generation and become a medium for testing how viewers perceive responsibility?

Method / Form

The work is built through a prompt-to-shot workflow using AI video generation and cinematic editing. Instead of starting from a conventional script and camera crew, the project begins with a sequence of situations: movement through water, obstructed visibility, unstable ground, bodily urgency, and the encounter with another vulnerable life. These situations are translated into a coherent cinematic experience.

The first-person structure is central. It removes the safe distance of the external observer. The viewer is placed inside a moving body whose field of vision is partial and unstable. Here the camera functions as a perceptual interface.

Argument / Contribution

Threshold argues that AI-generated cinema should not be understood only as a tool for producing images faster. Its deeper potential lies in constructing difficult perceptual situations: moments that place the viewer inside a body that would be hard to stage physically.

The work also contributes to a research-art practice concerned with disaster imagination. The question is what happens when the interface between viewer and image becomes bodily: when seeing becomes moving, and moving becomes choosing.

What to Notice

Notice the first-person perspective and the instability of the camera; the movement through water; and the way the scene shifts from environment to ethical pressure. The most important threshold is the moment when the viewer recognizes that decisions are happening at once.

The film's AI-native production is part of the work. Its synthetic realism reveals a developing cinematic language in which disaster is simulated as an embodied field of perception.

Status

Version 0.1 exhibition working paper. *Threshold* is the first film Wang Yan conceived and produced independently, and it is an early step toward a larger body of work connecting AI-generated cinema.